Poems for Church

Contents

Clean Me (Baptism) 2
Instability at Christmas 3
Can I have? (Christmas) 4
Christmas is 7
A nice church (People, not the Building) 8
Why? 9
God talks 10
Seams (on the need for rest) 11
Just a second (Easter) 12
Modern Life (on the need for rest) 13
For Rob and Nancy (marriage) 14
The number 34 bus (drawing people in) 14
The tightrope walker (redemption) 15
Paradoxology (many faces of God) 16
The fish's tale (big bones) (Jonah) 17
It's not about the fish (Jonah's take on it) 19
I'm determined (forgiveness) 21
Donations welcome (Easter) 23
Armour-Lite (the armour of God) 24
Let there be science (creation) 25
Decisions, Decisions (saviour or charlatan) 26
Chronicling stuff (God knows you) 27
Christmas presents 28
This is a church 30
Such a place 2025, Woking URC 31

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Clean Me

Hot iron and tissue
For the wax on my trouser
Cold water and salt
For the wine on my shirt
Grasshopper-green goo
For the oil on my fingers
And seaweed and comfrey
Soak the grime from my skin
Squeaky clean me!

On the outside at least,
But inside…

Inside, I stink.

What can scrub clean in there?
What will wash the world's wounds
The grief and the pain
The lies and deceptions –
That internal stain…

That infernal stain

Oh to rise from the water
And be washed through and through…



© 2026 Simon Harrison

Instability at Christmas

In these times of change,
Of uncertainty,
Of war,
It's good to know at Christmas,
We have a Stable King.



© 2026 Simon Harrison

Can I have?

It’s always the same:
Can I have, can I have, can I have?
Says son to dad at Christmas time.
Can I have, can I have, can I have?

Can I have a Game Cube,
An X-Box, a car,
Subbuteo, Playmobil,
Electric guitar?

Can I have a model,
A Hornby railway track?
Some pencils, a rubber
Or any old tack.

Can I have a Nokia,
A GPS, a PSP?
Can I have a PDA
With LCD and MP3?

Or how about an etch-a-sketch
A spirograph, a DVD?
Can I have some football boots
A cricket bat, a new TV?

Can I have, can I have, can I have?

I can’t complain – I was the same
Can I have, can I have, can I have?

Can I have an Action Man,
A Rubix Cube, a sailing boat?
Can I have a Commodore
A chopper bike, a parka coat?

Can I have, can I have, can I have?

But then it was always the same:
Can I have, can I have, can I have?
Said the Son to the Father that first Christmas time
Can I have, can I have, can I have?

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Can I have gold, frankincense, and myrrh?
A cot in a cave, and a Virgin birth?
A cross on a hill, and a crown of thorns?
Rejection, betrayal, and pain…

Can I have the punishment belonging to others?
The sentence that pays for their crime?

Can I have, can I have, can I have?

Can I have salvation –
For all those who want it?
Redemption, resurrection, and life?

– and can I have life
In *all* its fullness?
Excitement, fulfilment – that buzz?

And can I have freedom for the slave?
And can I have victory over the grave?
And can I have hope for the despairing?
Comfort for the grieving?
Relief for the hurting?
Mercy for the fearing?

And can I have light in the darkness?
Sense in the chaos?
A harbour from the storm?

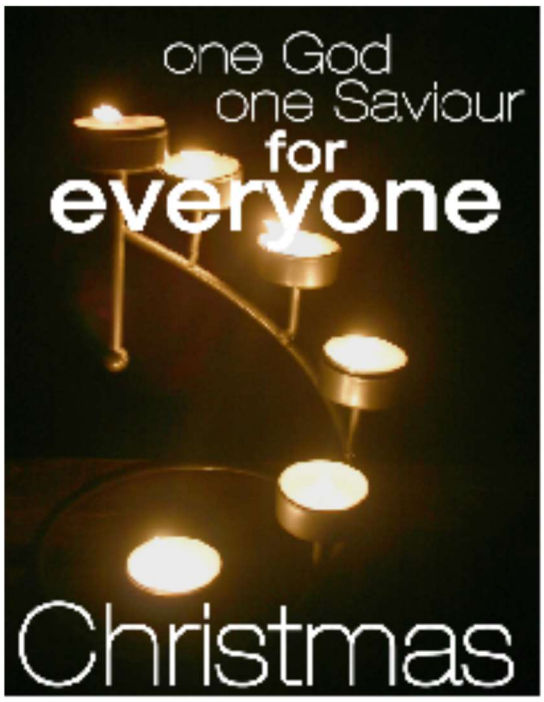
And can...

Can?

I have!

I have them

© 2026 Simon Harrison



© 2026 Simon Harrison

Christmas is...

Christmas is on BBC
Christmas is on ITV
Christmas is at M&S
Christmas is Baileys on ice
Christmas
Is a commercial opportunity

No, that's wrong

Christmas is Santa, sleighbells and snowballs
Christmas is gifts under the tree and surprises
Christmas is lights, tinsel and magic
Christmas
Is for the kids

No - hang on

Christmas is unwanted presents and loneliness
Christmas is hours spent in the kitchen, slaving over a hot stove while YOU sit in here drinking and watching James Bond and then your parents turn up with Billy, and does anyone lift a finger to help...

NO NO NO

Actually...
You know,
Actually

Christmas is a birthday
Christmas is hope for the future and life eternal
Christmas is forgiveness, peace and reconciliation
Christmas
Is nothing without Easter

© 2026 Simon Harrison

A nice church

A brass cross blazes in the morning light;
A mighty eagle holds a bible on outstretched wings;
Lilies and lavender scent the sanctuary
And a single candle flickers among cascades of wax.

Mrs Jones hasn't spoken to Mrs Smith for five years:
They disagreed about a parking space
Fred won't sing – not since they replaced the organ
With that modern, electric thing.

The tower is Norman:
Remnant of an earlier place of worship.
But Norman won't worship
Not here, not with *him* singing in the choir
Not after what he said about his wife.

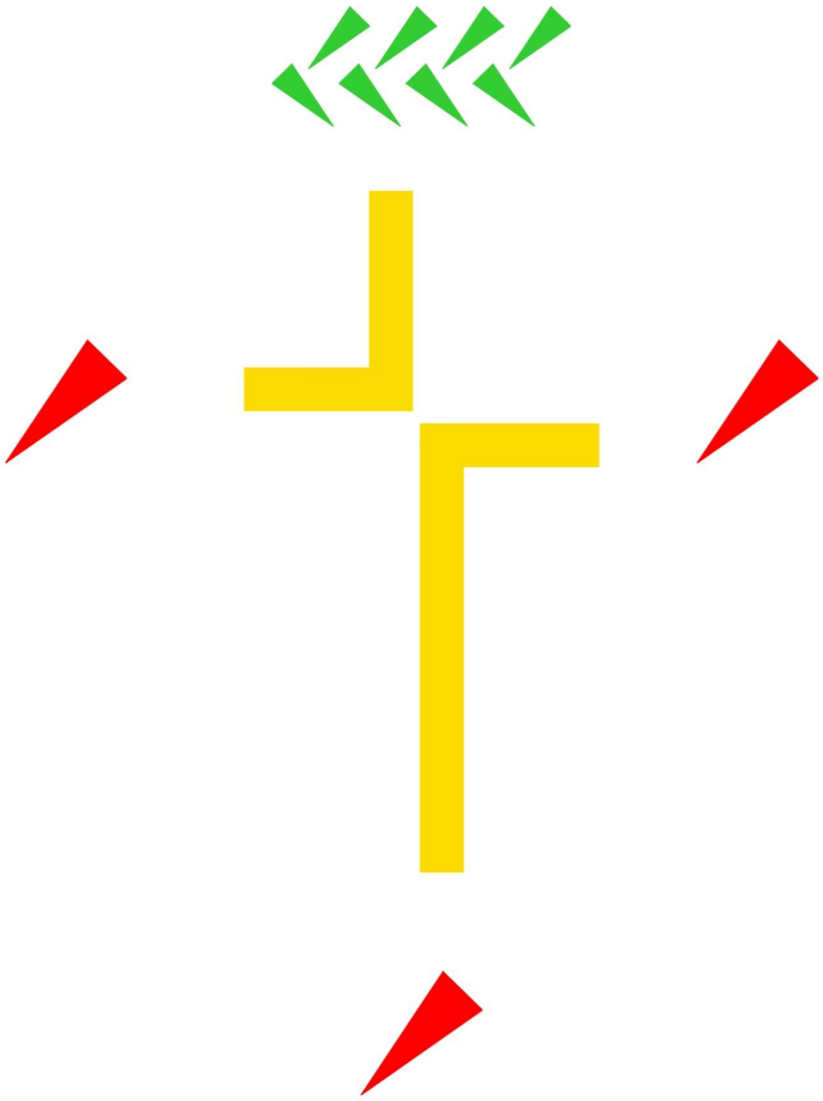
The choir sings like angels,
Between bouts of petulance.
The memorial gleams, with its "lest we forget"
While veterans who lived
Sit at home,
Forgot.

Nice building:
Shame about the church.

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Why?

Why am i in pain, and not in love?
Why are u in trouble, and not in peace?
Why is he in hell, when he could be in heaven?
And why is she in her shell, and surrounding shame?
Why are we caught in a web, and they mixed up in their theology?
Because we need Emmanuel, God is with jesus



© 2026 Simon Harrison

God talks

SHOUTING SHOUTING SHOUTING
that still
NOISE COMMOTION STRIFE
small voice
WHAT'S ON THE OTHER SIDE?
can
CHANGE CHANNEL! CHANGE CHANNEL!
be hard
WILL YOU KIDS KEEP THE NOISE DOWN?
to hear
HE STARTED IT! IT WASN'T ME!
at times
I NEVER DID! I NEVER DID!

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Seams

Hobbling along from day to day
The week walks by while we collide –
Icebergs in an Arctic sea

I rush along, I hide from peace
No time for me, no time to sleep
No time for God, no time for you
No time to stop (just time to waste)
No time for me (just time to waste)
No time for sleep (just time to waste)
No time for God (just time to waste)
No time for you (just life to waste)

The TV's on, the hi-fi blares
The doorbell rings, my temper flares
A meeting more, a social whirl
My head hurts (and my soul screams)
A meeting more (and my soul screams)
A social whirl (and my soul screams)
No time for God (and my soul screams)
No time for you (and my heart screams)

My life is falling a part
at the

Seems I've made it to another Sunday
Seems I've made it through another week
Seems I've made it for another Monday

Seams intact for another week
Soul's intact for another
(weak)

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Just a second

What was the most significant second?
What do you think?
Which would you choose?

Cos seconds come
and seconds go
but seconds don't get a
nother chance.

Would you choose a happy second?
I do
It's a boy
Some people are on the pitch…

Or a momentous second:
A giant leap for mankind?

Or maybe a scorned second:
The first shot of war
The first sign of sickness
The first sigh of separation

Or that darkest of all seconds
As the innocent,
Nailed to a tree,
Breathes His last.

It is finished.

Only horror days later you discover
it was the best second
the blessed second
the life-giving, soul-saving, redemption-filled second

the second to live for

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Modern Life

Today
    I am feeling a little bit
Down
    Stairs I dash – no time for break
Fast
    Cars, fast food, fast women, fast
Living
    On the edge all the
Time
    For work, time to run, no time to
Waist
    Line increasing daily
Dis
    Connected
In
    Complete
My

    Life

        Slipping

                                                Away

© 2026 Simon Harrison

For Rob and Nancy

There's a party in heaven this evening
The angels are holding a ball,
The saints are having a knees-up,
And the cherubs can stay up till dawn.

Jesus is laughing and smiling
Remembering the water made wine
Cos the marvellous mathematical God,
The wonderful creator of all,

Has taken the blushing bride
And the nervous groom
To make one plus one,
With Him, make one.

Rob and Nancy's wedding 22 October 2005

The number 34 bus

God's route through life
Is a bit like the number 34 bus.

It doesn't take you by the direct route -
Down Westfield Avenue.

It goes via Kingfield.
To pick up others.

© 2026 Simon Harrison

The tightrope walker

As I set out
On the tightrope of life
I spread my arms wide
And step out with care.



One slip of the foot
Means that I fall
One slip of the eye
Means that I fall
One slip of the mind
Means that I fall
Lose sight of the goal
Means that I fall

There's no
"I only just fell"
There's just
"I fell".
There's no
"I almost stayed on"
There's just
"I fell".
There's no
"It was only one slip"
There's just
"I fell".

I may as well have jumped:
Cos I fell.

Except

Except I have a friend
Who spread His arms wide
To pick me back up
Each time that I fall

And I fall quite a lot...

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Paradoxology

My God is a great growling lion with fierce teeth and claws
Lain on a manger of hay.
My God is a mighty warrior with a flaming sword, trampling His enemies under His feet
The Prince of Peace.
My God put the stars in the sky, built the mountains, filled the seas
And put the petals on the daisy.
My God is baby Jesus, meek and mild
Trashing tables in the temple.
My God is interested in politics, poverty, the environment,
Football, guitars, and me.
My God is King of Kings, Lord of Lords, the Chief Exec of Life
And my mate down the pub.
My God holds life and death in His hands
And gave His life for me.
My God is all of these things
And more.

My God is SO cool.



© 2026 Simon Harrison

The fish's tale (big bones)

Jonah from the fish's perspective.
It's common for people to picture God as being from where they are from. I'm from Stoke-on-Trent, so for me, Father God is from North Staffordshire and speaks with a Potteries accent.

I've always been a big fish
Ever since I was really small.
Although, if I think about it,
That doesn't make sense at all

I guess what I'm trying to say
Among all the griping and groans
Is I'm not *that* overweight, you know
It's just that I've got big bones.

My friends all call me Marty
My parents call me Maritime
That's quite an unusual name, I guess:
But it doesn't half help with the rhyme...

As an aside now please remember:
In His own image God made "bloke"
So don't be surprised if in a little while
God sounds like he comes from Stoke.

Well, one day while happily swimming,
In the deep blue seas of the Med,
A booming Potteries voice called out
And this is what it said:

"Ay up there now, young Marty
I've got a job for thee.
So listen up right good, lad
And hear what's going to be.

"Thah's off on a trip to to the Costas
Where a bloke on a job for me
Has gone and upset all his shipmates
And is going to be chucked in t'sea!

"I want you to go off and fetch him
And put him straight back on my course
So what the job is about, my friend
Is to be my maritime horse!"

© 2026 Simon Harrison

To be honest, I weren't too pleased with this.
All my life, it's always the same
It's all a result of my size, you see:
And I'm getting sick of this game.

I guess what I'm trying to say
Among all the griping and groans
Is I'm not *that* overweight, you know
It's just that I've got big bones.

So I set off on my journey
To the coast of southern Spain
And swallowed up this Jonah chap
Who happened to be a right pain.

It wasn't the swallowing as such
That caused all my griping and groans –
Cos although I'm not overweight, you know
I do have quite big bones.

No, what was really the problem
The cause of all of my grief
Was the bloke I'd gone and swallowed
Was vowing beyond belief!

It's not that I dislike vowing
No, I beg of you, don't get me wrong.
It's just that it gets on your nerves a bit
When it's in you for three whole days long.

Three hard days swimming it took me –
Not bad for a fish with big bones
And I spewed him up onto the beach right then
And left him there sprawled in the stones.

So the moral of my little story
For those of you wanting to know
Is when God sends you somewhere different
Do us a favour: just go!

Another thing I want to remind you,
Among all my griping and groans
Is I'm not *that* overweight, you know
It's just that I've got...

© 2026 Simon Harrison

It’s not about the fish (Jonah’s take on it)

It’s not about the fish.
Will you stop going on about the fish.
It’s Not About The Fish.

What was it like inside?
Was it a whale?
Was it a monster?

The fish was a red herring
It’s not
about
the fish

I didn’t want to go to Nineveh
I hate the Ninevites -
Murdering, oppressing scum.

I didn’t want to go
Cos I knew what He’d do
What He Always Does.

You don’t need a ship to get to Nineveh
Just ask my brothers.
But I took a ship.

But it didn’t go well,
And you know what happened next
The bit about the f...
...unny journey I had.

It’s not about the fish.

I wanted the Ninevites to suffer
The murdering, oppressing scum
I wanted them to suffer.

Like we suffered.

But they listened
And He did what I knew He’d do
What He Always Does.

He showed them mercy.

He always shows mercy

© 2026 Simon Harrison

He loves people
All people.

Even murdering, oppressing scum.

© 2026 Simon Harrison

I’m determined

I’ll never forgive you
Cos you hurt me:
I can’t believe what you did.
You hurt me,
I’ll never forgive you.
I’m determined to make myself pay.

It’s an open wound I keep prodding
A sore that I’ll never let heal.
I’m festering, festering, festering, and
I’m gonna keep on hurting
Cos it’s the only way I can get you.
Even when it’s clear that I can’t.

I’m gonna keep on hating
I’m gonna keep on plotting
The things I should have said.
I’m gonna spend hours,
Deliciously hateful hours.
Dreaming of things I daren’t do.

I imagine you suffering in public
I revisit things every night
I wish I’d said something so witty, cos
You hurt me,
I’ll never forgive you.
I’m determined to make myself pay.

You carry on all oblivious
As if my pain wasn’t real
Your life seems so unaffected, but
You hurt me,
I’ll never forgive you.
I’m determined to make myself pay.

I’ve been carrying this pain ten years now -
As fresh as the day it was born.
It’s a wound I love to keep prodding
A sore that I’ll never let heal.
Around and round my head it whirls,
I can never let it go, cos

© 2026 Simon Harrison

You hurt me,
I'll never forgive you.
I'm determined to make myself pay.

You hurt me,
I cannot forgive you.
How am I the one who must pay?

You hurt me,
I will not forgive you.
I'm...

Stuck

But remember: Jesus can set you free

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Donations welcome

Gave.

Not conceded or lost,
Not stolen or taken.
But given.
Freely given.

I chose
To give my life for you
For free.

No charge,
No debt,
No return expected.

But donations are welcome.

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Armour-Lite

Owing to a lack of exercise
I find my belt of truth a little...
Restricting
So I've drilled another hole.
And now my looser truth belt
Has been stretched to fit.

Similarly,
My breastplate of righteousness
Pinches a little
So I've swapped it
For a sweatshop sweatshirt
Of exploitation.

My feet were fitted with the readiness
That comes from the gospel of peace.
But now they're fitted with the laziness
That comes from the cod, chips and peas
And a couple of pints with the footie.
(Come on you Cards!)

And have you seen what the helmet of salvation does
To your hair?

My shield of faith
(Which extinguishes the flaming arrows of the evil one)
Is a little rusty
Especially around the holes.
I don't intend to test it.

And as for my sword of the spirit
(which is the word of God)
What a nasty, sharp thing that is!
I nearly cut myself
There was almost blood.
So I've safely stowed it away
In the dusty scabbard of apathy
Which is the bookcase in the spare room.

So there it is -
The armour of God doesn't quite
Suit the current me.
But I'm sure I'll be alright
With my Arnour-Lite.

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Let there be science

The earth was formless and empty,
Darkness was over the surface of the deep,
And the Spirit of God was hovering over the waters.

And God said,

> Let there be atoms.
>
> And let the atoms have a nucleus
> Made of protons -
> And neutrons, for added bulk.
>
> And around the outside of the nucleus
> Let there be electrons,
> To balance the charge.
>
> And let the electrons
> Be tiny little whizzing particles...
> Or maybe waves.
>
> And when the atoms get some energy
> Let the electrons jump up
> In their excitement.
>
> And when they've had enough excitement
> Let them drop back down
> And release their energy.

And there was light.

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Decisions, Decisions

Wake or snooze?
Slippers or barefoot?
Tea or coffee?
Cereal or toast?
Shave or stubble?
Red tie or blue tie?
Walk or drive?
Stairs or lift?
Tea or coffee (again)?
Answer phone or ignore it and say "I must have been away from my desk - probably gone to the loo or something"?
Jacket potato or sandwiches?
Stairs or lift (again)?
Tea or coffee (again)?
Finish report or stare out of the window.....

Work late or skive off early?
Straight home or pub?
Eat in or eat out?
Early night or sit up watching American chat show host interview someone I've never heard of...

Decisions, decisions
You've got to make them
Or they're taken away
And you're left with nothing.

Saviour or charlatan?
Christ or conman?
Man with a soul or collection of chemical impulses?
Which do you have enough faith to believe?

Is this it?
Or is there more to life
Than just life?

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Chronicling stuff

God knows a lot of folk, you know.
God knows a lot of folk.

There's Kenan and Enoch and Noah and Shem,
Kittim and Jared and Ham.
There's Gomer and Javan, Raamah and Canaan
Sabta and Ludim and Put.

The Jebusites, Amorites, Hivites and Arkites
The Sinites, Levites, descendants of Hur.
The daughters of Sheshan, the sisters of Jesse,
Caleb, and Peleth, and Uz.

Sheba, Dedan, Nimrod, Heth,
Ophir, Heber, and Ram,
Elah, Pinon, Timna, John,
Hezron, Sheber, Er.

(Ooooh - and Er, Judah's eldest, was evil in the Lord's sight, so the Lord slew him.)

Helah, Naarath, Zerar, Harum,
Ohel, Arnan, Akkub, Saul,
Chelub, Shuhah, Kenaz, Ishi,
Elah, Iru, Jalon, Shaul.

Gilead, Joshua, Simeon, and Amran,
The Gershomites, Ephraimites, and the tribe of Gad.
The sons of Jether and the offspring of Asher,
Yet God knows the number of hairs on your head.

Yet God knows the number of hairs on your head.

God knows a lot of folk, you know.
God knows a lot of folk.

Yet God knows
The number of hairs
On your head.

(Although some of us are making them easier to count!)

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Christmas presents

Ten Lords-a-Leaping.

What am I supposed to do
With ten leaping lords?
To be honest, one would be plenty.
And I think I'd prefer him not to jump about too much.
In fact, if he started jumping about,
I'd point at him and say "You're Fired!"

And what's with all the wildfowl?
Calling birds, french hens, turtle doves.
The partridge even comes with its own pear tree
In some bizarre sort of "buy one, get one free" offer.

And don't get me started on the pipers piping
Or the drummers drumming.
(One of them is certainly enough.)
Although the golden rings are fine.
I mean - they're traditional, aren't they?
Gold was brought by the wise men.

Very wise, too, gold.
You can't go wrong with gold
Sort of the biblical gift voucher.
"I didn't know what to get - here's something to spend
In the post-census sales."

Although the frankincense and myrrh were a bit strange.
Surely unsuitable for children under three years.
May contain small parts.

What's wrong with cuddly toys and crayons?
If I were a shepherd, I would bring a lamb.
Although a lamb for the baby
Who was destined to be a sacrificial lamb
Does seem a little insensitive.

© 2026 Simon Harrison

So maybe the wise men really were wise:
Symbols of worship and death
For for the baby king of kings
Who was to die for me.

You see, the best Christmas present isn't found
Wrapped in paper under the Christmas tree,
But was found wrapped in swaddling clothes in a manger.
The best Christmas present is the birthday boy himself.

So this Christmas, please:
Let's have fewer acrobatic aristocrats,
More golden rings
And don't forget the birthday boy.

© 2026 Simon Harrison

This is a church

THIS IS A CHURCH
A rescue centre for losers, failures, and the chronically imperfect
If you have life sorted, know where you're going, and are perfect
Then you must be Jesus.
In either case, come on in. You're welcome.

THIS IS A CHURCH
The home of truth and love
If you lie and hate
Then own it, apologize, and move on
But come on in. You're welcome.

THIS IS A CHURCH
A place of praise and worship
Where God is at the centre
If you prefer to be at the centre
Then own it, apologize, and move on
But come on in You're welcome.

THIS IS A CHURCH
The home of joy and hope
If you are sad and despairing
Then know you are loved
And come on in and be cared for
This is the home of the Prince of Peace
And there's no better place to be.

THIS IS A CHURCH
DON'T EVER FORGET IT

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Such a place 2025, Woking URC

Tel est cet endroit

Such a place this is
Where Man meets God
And sings His praises

Where young and old
Are both at home
And play their part

Where proud new mums
Bring babes for doting
And fears for calming

Where cocky kids
Can teach their elders
And yet learn grace.

Áit aoibhinn mar seo
Indawo eyo xolo njenga lapha

Such a place this is
Halfway up a hill, a light that shines
As bright as any on a summit

Where the godly rise at an ungodly hour
To serve their neighbours
And open doors draw people in
To clubs for community, jabs for immunity
All covered by the love of the Christ who cares.

这样的美丽地方 (zhe yang de mei li di fang)

Such a place this is
Where broken hearts find healing
And the downtrodden are lifted up

Where those who were told that they can't
Now find they can
And teach others how

© 2026 Simon Harrison

Where the tuneless sing like angels
When God is in their hearts
And the sad are wrapped in arms that fear no tears.
(come cry with us)

Dette er et sted fylt av glede

Such a place this is
Filled with the blessed and the blessing
The cared for and the caring
The annoyed and annoying
The frustrated and frustrating
The imperfect and the sinful.

And yet
The smiling saviour looks down on it all
And makes it good
And sets us right.

এটা এমন একটা জায়গা (Ey jamon akta jāyga)
இது ஒரு அருமையான இடம் (ithu oru arumaiyana idam)

Such a place this is
Such a beautiful, joyful place of hope and forgiveness
Such a place this is
And I love it.

© 2026 Simon Harrison